

THE RIGHT MAN FOR TOUGH JOBS

► Kant worked on several tourism campaigns, including Kerala: God's Own Country and Incredible India

► During his tenure as DIPP Secretary, he worked on Make in India and Startup India and drove the Ease of Doing Business initiative

► As CEO of NITI Aayog, Kant was associated with the Aspirational Districts programme, the PLI scheme, India's National Mission on Transformative Mobility and Battery Storage, and SDGs

► He also served as Chairman and CEO of the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor Development Corporation

NAVIGATING INDIA'S G20 PRESIDENCY

► A global slowdown and Covid-19 had impacted economies when India took over the G20 presidency

► Kant, as the G20 Sherpa, also had to deal with the twin challenges of climate action and climate finance

► He successfully navigated the challenge of making the G20 more inclusive

► He was able to highlight India's achievements like its economic success story and DPI

► Despite the Russia-Ukraine war impacting multilateralism, Kant was instrumental in the G20 reaching a consensus on various issues

the Incredible India campaign in 2002, where O&M was the ad agency, with V. Sunil as the Creative Director. "Amitabh was able to take it through to the government and then Tourism Minister Jagmohan and convince them to use it even though it was so different from other government campaigns that had a lot of copy," Pandey recalls.

"We have all seen the fantastic job he did at NITI Aayog as well as what he achieved in India's presidency of the G20. I credit him with also improving my English vocabulary as I did not know that a Sherpa can be someone apart from the person who helps another person climb a mountain," adds Pandey.

When asked about the secret of his success, Kant credits his out-of-the-box thinking and leadership skills to his mindset and hard work. "My view always has been that you need to think about 30 years ahead on how you want to shape the country or the particular sector that you want to work in. Don't be a status quoist; you need to be a visionary. Second, always study and see how the world is changing," he says, adding that it is essential to keep abreast of new technologies and keep reading.

Kant's passion for knowledge is evident from the fact that he has constantly worked to refresh his views and learn more. A master's from Jawaharlal Nehru University, he is also a Chevening Scholar. He has undertaken a mid-term course with the John F. Kennedy School of Government at Harvard University and IIM Ahmedabad.

An experienced policymaker, he also believes in taking his team along and striving for excellence. "I believe, in government, that you have your good days [and] bad days; but you should always take your team along. Taking your team along is very critical; they must be a part of your whole strategy of growth," he says, adding that he believes in always working with young people.

"They bring in a lot of fresh ideas and creativity. And lastly, I would say that I've never worked with mediocrity; I will always work with the best people," Kant underscores.

So, even as India was winning global accolades for clinching the Delhi Declaration, Kant took out time to thank his colleagues across the G20 Secretariat for their work in reaching consensus on the communiqué; officers of the Finance Track; as well as the Indian Foreign Service officers who assisted in drafting the paragraphs on the Russia-Ukraine war.

"Phenomenal team of young officers who delivered the #G20. Tremendous energy, vibrancy, dy-